Decide How Your Family Will Talk About Your Father's Care Before It Matters

Four prompts to notice how your family already handles disagreement, draft a few simple ground rules everyone could live with, practice saying a limit out loud, and agree how you'd write down what gets decided.

Where you are

Your father is fine. The last time your family tried to decide something together it was a holiday menu, and it still got tense. You can see that one day the decisions will be about him, and you'd rather work out how to talk now, while nobody is tired or scared.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can describe how your family tends to handle disagreement, propose two or three ground rules for talking about your father's care, and show how a commitment or an open question would get written down.

A one-page draft discussion agreement with headings: How we talk now, Ground rules to propose, How we'll say a limit, How we'll record decisions and open questions, and Who else we'd ask if we got stuck.

Before you start

- A memory of the last time your family made a decision together, and how it went.
- A rough sense of each relative's communication style: who calls, who texts, who goes quiet.
- Anything your father has said about how he'd want decisions made. You don't need to have asked him yet.

PROMPT 1

Notice how your family already decides things

WHY THIS MATTERS

Your family already has a way of handling disagreement; it just hasn't been named. Naming it while the stakes are a dinner menu is a lot easier than naming it in a hospital corridor.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Two or three memories of family decisions, big or small, and how each went.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My father is well and nothing needs deciding right now. I want my family to work out how we'll talk about his care before we have to. Here are two or three times we made a decision together, large or small, and how each one went:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Look for patterns, not blame. Give me two lists: WHAT HELPED, things that moved the conversation along, and WHAT GOT IN THE WAY, things that stalled it or made it tense. Describe each in one plain sentence tied to something I wrote. Then note who tends to speak first and who tends to go quiet, if I gave you enough to tell. Do not label anyone's personality or diagnose the family.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A pattern that shows up in more than one story, because that is the one worth a ground rule.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask one sibling whether the two lists match their memory, and expect them to add a thing or two.

PROMPT 2

Draft ground rules everyone could live with

WHY THIS MATTERS

Ground rules work when they are few, short, and sound like your family. Five rules written as things you will do beat twenty written as things you won't.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The two lists from the first prompt.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've noticed about how my family handles decisions:
>
> [PASTE THE TWO LISTS FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> Draft three to five ground rules we could propose for talking about my father's care someday. Each rule should be one sentence, stated as something we will do rather than something we won't, and tied to one pattern from my lists. Include one rule about how any of us can say 'I can't take that on' without it being treated as letting the family down, and one about what we do when

> a conversation gets stuck. For each rule, offer a second wording in case the first sounds too formal for us. Do not assign anyone a role.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Rules you could imagine your most skeptical relative agreeing to.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick the two you like best and float them with a sibling as a question, not a proposal.

PROMPT 3

Practice saying a limit and asking for something

WHY THIS MATTERS

The hardest sentences in family care are 'I can't do that' and 'Would you take this on?' Saying them for the first time in a made-up situation is much easier than saying them for the first time when it counts.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A made-up situation about dividing responsibilities, and a little about the relative you'd be talking to.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I want to practice two things before they matter: saying what I can't do, and asking a relative for something specific. Here is a made-up situation about dividing responsibilities for my father's care, and a little about the relative I'd be talking to:
>
> [DESCRIBE A HYPOTHETICAL SITUATION AND THE RELATIVE]
>
> Label everything as practice. Write three short scripts: one where I state a limit in two or three sentences without apologizing for it, one where I ask the relative for one specific contribution with a 'how often' attached, and one where I respond if they push back, in a way that keeps the conversation open. Keep my father's wishes in view in each script. Do not resolve the situation for us.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A limit you could say out loud without your voice going up at the end.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the scripts to someone outside the family and ask whether they sound like you.

PROMPT 4

Put the draft agreement on one page

WHY THIS MATTERS

The point of the page is not to settle anything. It is to give your family something concrete to argue with, which is a far better start than a blank table at Thanksgiving.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've worked on about how my family will talk about my father's care:
>
> [PASTE EVERYTHING FROM PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write one page with five headings: HOW WE TALK NOW, GROUND RULES TO PROPOSE, HOW WE'LL SAY A LIMIT, HOW WE'LL RECORD DECISIONS AND OPEN QUESTIONS, and WHO ELSE WE'D ASK IF WE GOT STUCK. Under the fourth heading, show a two-line example of how a commitment would be written, with a name and a date, and how an open question would be written. Under the last heading, list kinds of help a family might turn to, described in general, without naming a service. Mark the top 'draft for the family to edit.' Do not present this as agreed.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that reads as an invitation to your family, not a set of rules handed down.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Send it to everyone with one sentence, 'What would you change?', and then let it sit; there is no deadline.

A shared picture makes the conversation easier.

Families argue less when they are looking at the same facts. The care interview gathers your father's situation into a Family Care Profile, one document everyone can read, so future conversations start from what is true rather than from what each person remembers.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›